

Relay

A guide for you and the people you trust — what it does, how each part works, and why it is built the way it is.

Relay holds the things your family would need if you could not be reached — the account that everything else recovers through, the bank, the policy number, the instruction that only lives in your head — and hands them to specific people, only when specific people agree something has actually happened.

It is not a password manager, and it is not a will. A password manager assumes you are there to open it. A will assumes you are not coming back. Relay is for the long middle: the surgery, the accident, the three weeks in hospital, the trip where nobody could reach you. **Everything it does is reversible by you, right up until you choose something that is not.**

The one idea worth understanding

Nothing opens because a computer decided it should. Something opens because *people you named in advance* said it was real. Relay's job is to make that agreement possible at three in the morning, between people who may never have met, without any of them having to trust a stranger's email.

Three promises the design keeps, everywhere, without exception.

- **Relay never sends you a link that signs you in.** Not one. So any message claiming to be us that asks you to click one is, categorically, not us. This is why you type short codes instead of clicking links — it is mildly less convenient and it removes an entire class of attack on your family.
- **What is inside your vault never leaves your browser unencrypted.** Relay cannot read your items. Neither can anyone who steals the database.
- **Everything that happens is written to a record that cannot be edited or deleted** — including by us. That is what makes the summary you read afterwards trustworthy rather than merely reassuring.

What is in this guide

- Part 1** Setting it up — the four things you do once
- Part 2** Living with it — the part that lasts for years
- Part 3** For the people you name — what they see and what is asked of them
- Part 4** The day it matters — how a release actually runs
- Part 5** When something goes wrong — lost phones, false alarms, leaving
- Part 6** What Relay will not do, stated plainly

Setting it up

Four things, done once. Most people finish in under an hour, and the order matters more than the speed.

1.1 — Put in what actually matters

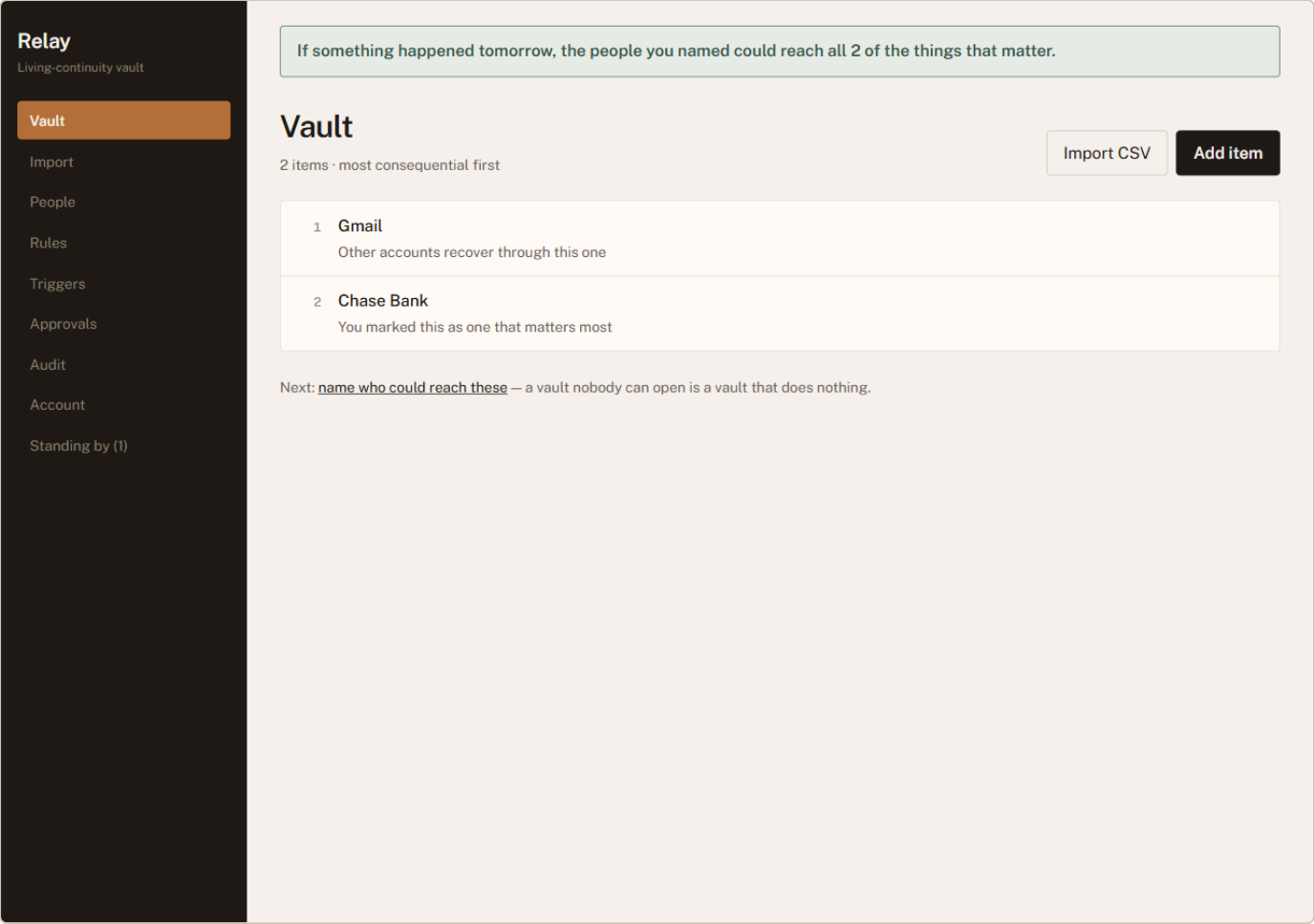
You · the Vault screen

Why this exists. The instinct is to put in everything. That is the wrong instinct, and it is the main reason plans like this fail: a list of ninety accounts is a list nobody can act on. Your family needs the four or five things that unlock the rest.

How it works. Add an item and Relay encrypts it *in your browser* before it is sent anywhere. It then scores each item for consequence and sorts the list with the most consequential first — the account that other accounts recover through outranks the one with the biggest balance, because losing the recovery path means losing everything downstream.

- Items are ordered by what would be hardest to live without, not by when you added them.
- The line under each item tells you *why* it is ranked where it is.
- **Import CSV** takes an export from a password manager if you would rather start from one.

The banner across the top is the single most useful thing on the screen. It answers one question — *if something happened tomorrow, would this work?* — and it is honest about the answer.



The vault, most consequential first. The prompt at the bottom points at the next thing that would actually help — a vault nobody can open is a vault that does nothing.

1.2 — Name the people

You · the People screen

Why this exists. Two different jobs get confused constantly, and confusing them is how a plan ends up doing nothing. **Some people receive access. Other people are asked whether the emergency is real.** They can be the same person, but the roles are separate, and a plan needs both.

ROLE	WHAT THEY DO	WHAT THEY SEE
Who would step in (recipients)	Receive access to the items you assign them, and only after a release opens.	Before a release: that they are standing by, for whom, and how much is set aside — counts and categories only, never titles.
Who confirms it is real (verifiers)	Answer one question — is this genuine? — and nothing else. They never receive access.	At the moment they are asked: how much is at stake and what kind of thing it is. Never a title, never a contents.

Naming someone is only the first half. Once they accept, Relay derives a short phrase from their account. You call them — an actual call — and check the phrase they read out matches the one on your screen. That call is what turns "someone with this email address accepted" into "this is my sister". Until you make it, **their answer does not count towards opening anything.**

Why a phone call, in a product that is otherwise entirely software. Every purely-digital way of proving identity here reduces to trusting an email inbox, and an inbox is the thing most likely to be compromised in exactly the scenario this product exists for. Two minutes on the phone is stronger than anything we could build, and it costs you one call per person, once.

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Standing by (1)

If something happened tomorrow, the people you named could reach all 2 of the things that matter.

People

Who would step in, who would be asked whether an emergency is real, and what each of them could reach.

Naming someone is the first half. Once they accept, call them and check the phrase matches — until you do, their answer would not count towards opening anything.

Everyone is named — but 2 of them have not been verified yet.
Until you check it is really them, their answer would not count and nothing would open. It is a two-minute call each.

Suggested starting point

Built from what the importance engine already knows. Accept what fits.

Aunt Margaret gets act access to 1 item on an emergency trigger
Root credentials are the reset path for everything else. Without them, nothing else can be recovered.
Accept

Aunt Margaret gets view access to 1 item on an emergency trigger
Critical money and health accounts are what a caregiver reaches for first.
Accept

Who holds what

PERSON	ROLE	ITEMS REACHABLE
Aunt Margaret	recipient	0 / 2
Jordan Rivera	partner	2 / 2

Who would step in

The people who would receive access. Nothing opens for them until a trigger fires and the people you named confirm it is real — and a person you have not verified cannot receive anything.

- Aunt Margaret recipient Emergency code only

uc-margaret-qa@relaystandby.com

Covered by an emergency code only — Aunt Margaret will not count towards your plan, by your choice. Undo

Emergency code

Remove
- Jordan Rivera partner Verified — their answer counts

uc-spouse-qa@relaystandby.com

Can sign in on a new device.

Verified — undo

Emergency code

Remove

recipient

▼

Add this person

Who confirms it is real

They are asked whether an emergency is real. Their answer only counts once you have checked it is really them. They never see what is inside your vault — only how much, and only when they are asked.

- Dr. Alex Chen Verified — their answer counts

uc-doc-qa@relaystandby.com

No passkey — an emergency code is their only way back in. Worth checking Dr. Alex Chen still knows where it is.

Verified — undo

Emergency code

Remove
- Pat Morgan Has not accepted yet — give them their code

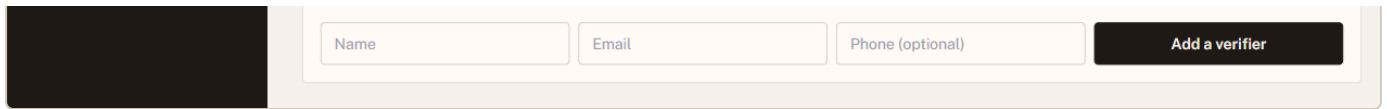
uc-pat-qa@relaystandby.com

Give them a code

Pat Morgan cannot use an account

Emergency code

Remove



The People screen: the coverage table, then the two rosters. Each person's line says what is still missing rather than merely what state they are in.

1.3 — Decide who can reach what

You · the Rules screen

Why this exists. "My family gets everything" is not a plan, it is an abdication. The person helping with your mother's care needs the health portal and the utility account; they do not need your solicitor's file. Scoping access is what makes it safe to name more than one person.

A rule is one sentence: *this item* → *this person*, under *this kind of emergency*, to *view* or to *act*. You can build them by hand, or accept the suggestions Relay drafts from what it already knows about your items — most people accept the draft and edit two lines.

- **View** means read it. **Act** means use it — sign in, pay the bill, call the bank.
- **Reversible** means access closes again when you check back in. This is the default and it is the whole reason an emergency release is not frightening.
- **Release after N days** holds a rule back — useful when you want the urgent things open immediately and the rest only if you are still unreachable a week later.

Estate rules are permanent and Relay will not let you pretend otherwise. The reversible option is disabled for them, because a handover that can be taken back is not a handover. Everything else can be undone by checking in.

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If something happened tomorrow, the people you named could reach all 2 of the things that matter.

Access Rules

Grant a recipient scoped access to an item under a trigger.

Gmail → Jordan Rivera
emergency · view · reversible

Remove

Chase Bank → Jordan Rivera
emergency · view · reversible

Remove

NEW RULE

Vault item

Select an item...

Recipient

Select a recipient...

Trigger type

emergency

Scope

view

☒ Reversible

Release after

0

days

Add rule

Existing rules read as sentences. The trigger a rule is written for is created the moment you write the rule — which is why an unused trigger never appears and can never fire.

1.4 — Set the conditions

You · the Triggers screen

Why this exists. The dangerous failure is not "it opened too late". It is "it opened when nothing was wrong". Every default here leans towards staying shut.

Two settings, and one button you will hopefully never press.

- **Check-in interval.** How long Relay waits before it starts asking whether you are all right. Thirty days suits most people. Any deliberate action in the product counts as checking in, so ordinary use keeps it quiet — you are not being asked to remember a chore.
- **Required confirmations.** How many of your verifiers must agree before anything opens. One is enough for a small circle. Two is meaningfully harder to fake and is worth it if you have three or more verified people.
- **Initiate** fires that trigger yourself, now — the "I know I am about to be unreachable" button. It still requires your verifiers to confirm. It does not skip anyone.

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Triggers

Release state, check-in cadence, and (for demo accounts) the simulate control.

Check-in interval (days)

30

Save

I'm fine — check in

RELEASE STATES

Emergency

ARMED

0/1 confirmations

Initiate

Required confirmations (N):

1

Set

A trigger sits **ARMED** and does nothing until either you initiate it or you stop checking in. Armed is the safe state, and every failure inside Relay resolves back to it.

1.5 — Someone to help you set it up

You · the Approvals screen

Why this exists. The person who most needs this is often the least likely to do the typing — and the adult child who bought it is usually sitting next to them anyway. The alternative, in practice, is that they sign in as you, which destroys every guarantee in this document at once.

A helper can add and tidy your information. A helper can **never** open anything, decide who gets access, or touch a release — anything that changes who can reach what comes to you as a question. You choose them from people you have already named who have accepted, so this is always an *elevation* of somebody known rather than an introduction of somebody new.

It does nothing until you record how you agreed to it — together in person, on paper, or confirmed by them on a device. That record is not a formality: it is what makes handing somebody this help legitimate rather than merely convenient, and it is why “in person” and “on paper” are offered as equals rather than buried under a link.

Living with it

This is the part that lasts for years, and the part most products get wrong by demanding attention they have not earned.

2.1 — Knowing whether it would actually work

You · the banner on every screen

Why this exists. The worst outcome for a product like this is not failing. It is *appearing to work* for four years and then failing on the one day it is needed. So the banner is deliberately hard to satisfy and deliberately specific about what is missing.

It goes green when the plan could actually run — not when you have filled in every field. And when it is not green it names **the single fastest thing you could do next**, rather than listing everything imperfect about your setup.

WHAT IT SAYS	WHAT IT MEANS
Green	Enough verified people, enough coverage. If something happened tomorrow, this works.
Nobody could confirm	You have named verifiers but not verified them, so nothing can open. This is the most common state for a new plan and the phone call fixes it.
Your plan rests on one person	It works, but every verified person is needed and at least one of them has no way back in if they lose their phone. Not urgent; worth an afternoon.

2.2 — Checking in

You · anywhere

Signing in and doing something deliberate is a check-in. There is also an explicit **I'm fine — check in** button on the Triggers screen for when you want to be certain. A check-in does three things at once: it resets the clock, it reverses a release that is in progress, and it closes access that has already opened. One action, all of it.

2.3 — Reading what happened

You · the Audit screen

Why this exists. Coming home and finding that people could see your accounts is unsettling even when everything worked exactly as designed. The record is what converts that from a vague unease into something you can actually check.

The top of the screen is the story in sentences: what was raised, who confirmed it, what was opened, when it closed, and why. Beneath it is every entry in order, hash-chained so that changing any one of them breaks the chain visibly. **Verify chain** re-computes it in front of you.

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What happened

5 entries · append-only, hash-chained.

On 8/12/2026 an emergency was raised, Dr. Alex Chen confirmed it was real, and 1 thing you had set aside was opened. It is closed again now.

Gmail — opened 8/12/2026, 1:47:26 PM

Closed 8/12/2026, 1:47:26 PM — because you checked back in. Nothing else was reachable, and nothing stayed open.

Server: intact

Client: —

Verify chain

Every entry

The full record, in the order it happened. Nothing here can be edited or removed — that is what makes the summary above trustworthy rather than merely reassuring.

SEQ	TIME	ACTOR	ACTION	ENTITY	DETAIL	HASH
0	8/12/2026, 1:47:24 PM	owner:fb7e816f-193c-4706-a8bd-a44bc75b3d4d	break_glass_issued	verifier · 7b79c827	▶ view	92894584176b...
1	8/12/2026, 1:47:25 PM	recipient:fc3ee2d3-eb86-40d1-b099-37fde0270656	trigger_initiated	release_state · a2af0923	▶ view	a50aa3a1219d...
2	8/12/2026, 1:47:25 PM	verifier:7b79c827-9aeb-4350-af8c-4ab933256eae	verifier_confirmed	release_state · a2af0923	—	8df738f965ff...
3	8/12/2026, 1:47:26 PM	recipient:fc3ee2d3-eb86-40d1-b099-37fde0270656	vault_item_decrypted	vault_item · 8009b0db	▶ view	1b92e25dec2a...
4	8/12/2026, 1:47:26 PM	system	release_transition_armed	release_state · a2af0923	▶ view	cbf9bc1f19b9...

The summary answers the questions a person actually has. The table beneath is the proof that the summary is not just a nice sentence.

2.4 — Your account

You · the Account screen

Five things worth doing once, and one you may never need.

- **Your name.** This is how you appear to everyone you trust. Set it. An emergency message that says `someone@gmail.com` instead of "Margaret" is the worst possible moment for your family to wonder whether the message is real.
- **Passkey.** Your face, fingerprint or device PIN. Nothing to remember and nothing anyone can email you that a stranger could imitate.
- **Recovery codes.** Relay has no password. If you lose the phone with your authenticator on it, these are the only way back. Get them now, while you still can.
- **Export everything.** A readable file of every item, decrypted in your browser. Your data is yours and leaving is not punished.
- **Subscription.** Cancel any time. Nothing in your vault is deleted when a subscription ends — the free limits apply only to adding more.
- **Close this account.** Removes the vault, the people and the rules. Anyone relying on it loses access immediately, and this cannot be undone.

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Standing by (1)

If something happened tomorrow, the people you named could reach all 2 of the things that matter.

Your account

Take your data out, or close the account.

Your name

This is how you appear to the people you trust. They see it on every message Relay sends on your behalf — including the one that arrives when something has gone wrong, which is the worst possible moment for it to say an email address they do not recognise.

Margaret Chen

Save name

Passkey

Sign in with your face, fingerprint or device PIN — no code to find, and nothing we could email you that a stranger could imitate. Adding one also means a new phone does not lock you out.

Add a passkey

Recovery codes

Relay has no password. If you lose the phone with your authenticator on it, these codes are the only way back in — so if you cannot find the list you were given at signup, get a new one now, while you still can.

Issuing a new list immediately stops the old one working.

Issue new recovery codes

Subscription and billing

Relay is \$119 a year and renews automatically until you cancel. You can cancel at any time from this page. Nothing in your vault is deleted when a subscription ends — it stays exactly as it is, and the free limits apply only to adding more.

Manage or cancel subscription

Export everything

Downloads a readable file containing every item, decrypted here in your browser, plus the people you have designated. Keep it somewhere you would keep a password list — it is not protected once it leaves.

Export my vault

Close this account

Removes your vault, the people you designated, and your access rules. This cannot be undone, and anyone relying on this vault will lose their access immediately.

The tamper-evident event log is kept, exactly as our privacy page says. It holds no secrets — only the record of what happened and when.

Close my account

Leaving is a first-class path, not a support ticket. Export first, then close.

For the people you name

Hand this part to them. It is written to be read by someone who has just been asked to do something they did not sign up for.

3.1 — Someone has named you. What now?

Your person · the Accept screen

Why you are being asked to do anything at all, in advance. The alternative is that the first time you hear from Relay is during an emergency, in an email, asking you to make a decision about someone you love while holding a code you have never seen before. Accepting now — on a calm Tuesday — means that on the bad day you simply sign in as yourself. There is nothing to intercept, because nothing is sent.

How it works. The person who named you gives you a short code. They choose how: read out on a call, texted, written down, handed over. You type it in, and you have an account. It is free, it holds nothing of yours, and it exists so you can be recognised later.

Accepting does not open anything. It does not give you access to their vault, and it does not tell them anything except that you have seen it. If you would rather not be part of this, the honest thing is to say so — and there is a control for stepping down at any time.

RELAY

Enter your invitation code

Someone has named you in their Relay plan.
Type the code from the email they sent you.

Code from your email

4 K M P Q - 7 X R 2 W

Continue

Nothing is being opened. Accepting only tells them
you have seen it.

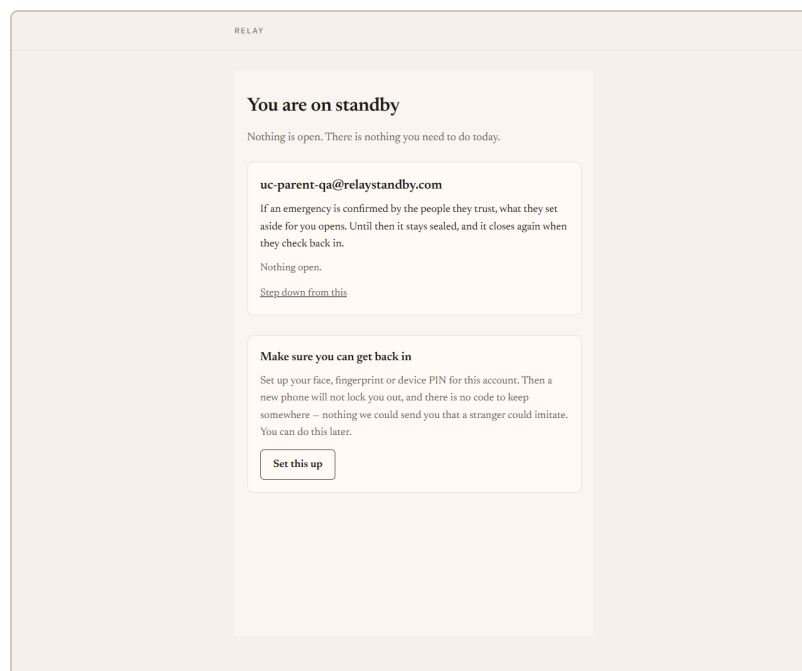
Typing a short code rather than clicking a link. That is deliberate: Relay never sends a link that signs you in, so a message with one in it is not from us.

3.2 — Standing by

Your person · their Standby screen

Most of the time this screen says the most valuable thing it can say: **nothing is open, and there is nothing you need to do today**. It shows who you are standing by for, what would happen if an emergency were confirmed, and — if you are a recipient — how much has been set aside for you, as counts and categories. Never titles. Never contents.

It also offers to set up a passkey. Worth doing: it is what lets you get back in on a new phone without anyone having to reissue anything, and it means there is no code to keep track of.



Standing by. **Step down from this** is always available — being named is not a trap, and someone who quietly stopped agreeing is worse than useless in an emergency.

3.3 — Asking them to open it

Your person · their Standby screen

Why this exists. The other paths all wait for something: for you to have anticipated the emergency, or for a check-in interval measured in weeks to run out. The commonest real case is neither — somebody is in hospital *now* and the person who would help needs to ask.

Next to “nothing is open” there is a control to ask. It says plainly, before the form is even shown, what asking costs: **you are asked first**, and **everyone else you named is told that a request was made**, whatever the outcome. That is deliberate rather than a side effect — it makes a quiet, covert attempt at somebody’s accounts impossible.

You then have a window to answer. If you cannot, the people you chose to confirm an emergency are asked instead — so it does not depend on you being reachable, which is the entire point. Nobody can wear you down with it either: three requests in twenty-four hours is the limit.

3.4 — The phone call

Both of you · two minutes, once

After you accept, the person who named you calls and asks you to read out a short phrase from your screen. If it matches theirs, they mark you verified and your answer starts counting. If it does not match, something is wrong and they should not proceed — that is the entire point of doing it out loud.

The day it matters

What actually happens, in order, and who is asked what.

4.1 — Something starts it

Either you initiated a trigger yourself, or you stopped checking in for longer than your interval and Relay began asking. The trigger moves from **ARMED** to **PENDING**. Nothing has opened.

4.2 — Your verifiers are asked one question

Your verifiers · the decision screen

Why a question and not a notification. A notification that fires automatically is a system that can be gamed by waiting. A person who knows you, answering "is this real?", cannot be.

Each verified verifier is contacted. What they receive depends on how they are set up, and only one case involves anything secret:

IF THEY...	THEY RECEIVE
have a passkey or an authenticator	A message telling them to sign in. No code, nothing to intercept.
are verified but have no way to sign in	A single-use code that expires in 72 hours. They need it; nobody else does.
were named but never verified	A message saying plainly that their answer would not count yet. Better than letting someone believe they helped.

They are shown **how much** is at stake and **what kind** of thing it is, so they can judge whether the request is proportionate. They are never shown a title and never shown contents. They can answer three ways — **yes, no, or I don't know** — and "no" is offered with exactly the same prominence as "yes".

Enter your code

Someone has asked you to confirm that a situation is genuine. Type the code from the email we sent you.

Code from your email

7 K 4 M - P 2 X W

Continue

You will never be shown anyone's private information — not now, and not after you answer. Relay will never send you a link that signs you in.

Code entry — the way in for a verified verifier who holds no passkey.

4.3 — The grace window

Once enough verifiers agree, the trigger enters **GRACE**. You are told, on every channel Relay has for you. If you are fine, checking in now stops everything. This window exists because the most likely emergency is a

misunderstanding.

4.4 — Access opens

Your recipients · their screen

Only now does anything open, and only what your rules assigned. Someone who accepted a standby account signs in as themselves; someone who never accepted receives a single-use code that lasts 24 hours. In both cases, decryption happens in their browser — Relay itself still cannot read the items.

RELAY

Enter your code

Someone arranged for you to reach their accounts, and that access is open. Type the code from the email we sent you.

Code from your email

7 K 4 M - P 2 X W

Continue

[My code has expired](#)

Relay will never send you a link that signs you in.

The recipient's way in when they never accepted a standby account. **My code has expired** re-sends to the address already on file — never to one typed here.

4.5 — It closes again

You check in. Every reversible grant closes, tokens stop working, and the whole episode becomes a paragraph on your audit screen. Nothing needs to be undone by hand.

When something goes wrong

The paths that matter most are the ones nobody rehearses.

5.1 — It was a false alarm

You · the Triggers screen

Stand down — re-arm stops a release in progress or closes one that has already opened, and puts the trigger back to armed and ready. This is the control you want almost every time.

Cancel permanently retires the trigger for good. It is deliberately separated and asks for confirmation, because someone stopping a false alarm at speed must not retire their whole plan by reaching for the innocuous-looking word on the screen.

5.2 — Someone lost their phone

Your person · the Emergency code screen

Why this exists. Not everyone owns a smartphone, and everyone eventually loses one. Without this, the seventy-year-old you most want to include is excluded by their own technology, and anyone whose authenticator is at the bottom of a river has to reach you — when you may be exactly the person who cannot be reached.

You can issue anyone an emergency code, in calm, to keep somewhere safe. It works once. When it is used, you are told, and you are asked to check it was really them.

Issue these in advance, not during the emergency. A code you would have to issue while unconscious is not a fallback. The banner will tell you when your plan depends on somebody who has no way back in.

Use your emergency code

If you were given a code to keep somewhere safe, type it here. It is the way back in when your usual sign-in is not available.

It works once. The person who gave it to you will be told that you used it, and they will be asked to check it was really you — that is deliberate, and it is what makes a code like this safe to carry.

Your emergency code

XXXX - XXXX - XXXX

Continue

No code? Ask the person who named you — they can issue a new one. Relay cannot send you one directly, because a code that arrives in an email is a code anyone who reaches that inbox could use.

The way back in when the usual sign-in is gone.

5.3 — The code never arrived, or ran out

Your person · the code screen

Both the access screen and the confirm screen carry “**my code has expired, or never arrived**”. It sends again — to the address already on file, never to one typed in, so it cannot be used to redirect anything at somebody else. What arrives depends on how that person is set up: a reminder to sign in if they have a passkey, a fresh code if they do not.

This matters most for the people confirming an emergency, because one of them being stuck holds up everybody else. If they still cannot get in, the others who were asked can still answer.

5.4 — Somebody cannot use an account at all

You · the People screen

Some people will never accept — no smartphone, no interest, no email they check. Marking them **emergency code only** tells Relay that this is deliberate, so it stops asking you to chase them. It is honest rather than quiet: it also says clearly that they will never count towards your plan working, and the banner arithmetic gets *louder*, not softer.

5.5 — Somebody wants out

Your person · their Standby screen

Step down from this removes them, tells you, and recalculates your plan. Someone who no longer wants the responsibility is not a safe person to depend on, so making this easy is a safety feature rather than a courtesy.

5.6 — You want out

You · the Account screen

Export everything first — it is a readable file, decrypted in your browser. Then close the account. Everyone relying on it loses access immediately. The tamper-evident event log is kept, as the privacy page says: it holds no secrets, only the record of what happened and when.

What Relay will not do

Stated plainly, because a product that overstates itself in this category is dangerous rather than merely disappointing.

- **It will not open on its own.** Silence never resolves towards open. If nobody confirms, nothing happens — which is the correct failure, and it means a plan whose people cannot be reached is a plan that does nothing.
- **It will not decide anything for your family.** It carries a decision your people make. It does not make one.
- **It cannot read your items, and cannot recover them for you.** The encryption that keeps them from us keeps them from us in every circumstance.
- **It will not make an unverified person count.** Naming someone is not verifying them. The phone call is not optional, and no amount of setup substitutes for it.
- **It is not a will.** An estate handover moves things to people you chose; it does not settle an estate, and it does not replace advice from someone qualified to give it.
- **It cannot help someone who has neither accepted nor been given a code.** That person is excluded by design, the product says so plainly rather than showing a hopeful amber light, and the fix is always the same: issue them a code while everything is calm.

The public pages

The landing page explains the product to someone who has never heard of it. The Terms and the Privacy page are written to be read — including the section addressed to people who did not sign up and were merely named by someone else, which is the population least served by ordinary legal boilerplate.

The accounts someone would need, if you could not manage them.

Relay holds them encrypted, opens only what you chose for the person you chose, and only once a real emergency has been confirmed by someone you trust — then closes again when you recover. One price for the whole family, \$119 a year.

I'm caring for a parent

[Show me what actually happens](#)

It closes again

Every other way of doing this is a door you open once. Recover, check in, and access ends on its own — which is what makes it safe to set up before you need it.

We cannot read it

Secrets are encrypted in your browser before they reach us. We hold ciphertext, and we are honest on [exactly what we can see](#).

Someone has to say yes

Nothing opens on a timer or a guess. A person you named confirms the situation is real, and never sees anything of yours.

Were you named by someone?

If someone has asked you to be a recipient or a trusted contact, you will have an email with a code in it. Enter it at relaystandby.com/claim. Relay never sends a link that signs you in — if a message claiming to be from us asks you to click one, it is not from us.